
The Material Network Of Empire: Household Objects, Sociability, and Mobility in Colonial India

Rohini Panicker*¹

¹Christ University – India

Abstract

The migration of European families to colonial India between the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries was accompanied by the movement of various household goods such as furniture, trunks, crockeries, books, dining utensils, and textiles across the Indian Ocean. The objects were carried to replicate and reproduce British domesticity in India and an imperial identity. The existing scholarship (Chattopadhyay 2002; Finn & Smith 2018; Nayar 2020) examined household objects as passive indicators of colonial hierarchical status and racial identity. However, they have not fully explored how household objects supplement or contribute to the formation of colonial domestic spaces. Two central questions guide this investigation: how did household goods sustain connections between India and Britain, materially embodying imperial belonging and the ‘cultural memory of home’? And, how did the circulation, display, and use of these objects create social networks among Europeans in India, reinforcing social status, while simultaneously enabling interaction, alliance-building, and a shared sense of colonial experience?

Ships serve as the first site of networked mobility within the imperial world, where household objects became the anchors of belonging at sea. The diaries and journals of memsahib reveal that they carried trunks, textiles, chairs, books and glass to furnish their cabins (de Courcy 2014) illustrating how household objects functioned as active agents and co-constructors of social life on board. The relationship between objects and networks was reciprocal, with both influencing and reshaping each other, most visibly expressed in the spatial architecture of the imperial empire, produced through material goods, carried, displayed and circulated by colonial subjects. Central to this process was the construction of cultural memory, which served to reinforce imperial identity across vast distances. A prime example of this was the ‘bottlekhana’ storehouses where liquor, tinned meat and pickles from Britain were stored (Chattopadhyay 2023). Termed immutable objects, they crossed oceans yet remained faithful carriers of British memory, social hierarchy and racial boundaries across space and time.

The integration of Actor-Network Theory (Latour 2005) and objectification theory (Tilley 2006) illuminates the profound and dynamic interplay between humans and objects. Tilley’s dialectical model posits a continuous and reciprocal interaction with humans and objects, wherein objects function as an extension of self, embodying subjectivity and actively shaping social relations. Latour’s notion of the ‘actant’ extends this further, casting objects as active participants that mediate and transform the networks they enter. Together, the frameworks position objects as ‘relational actors’ with an agency to determine the social life in colonial India.

*Speaker

This paper utilizes qualitative historical network analysis to trace the biographies, mobility, and relational linkages of specific material goods across textual and visual archives. Treating qualitative documents as network directories, the analysis maps the relational ties formed between human and non-human actors across geographical locales. The primary source corpus is diverse, drawing on memsahib diaries, personal journals, ship logs, household management books, cookbooks, advertisements, and domestic photographs. Through this methodology, the paper demonstrates how objects functioned as ‘relational actors’, active constituents of identity formation and integral to the construction of imperial empire’s social and spatial architecture.

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